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POLITICS

Boiled Frogs: A Case Study of One of Global Politics' Most Haunting Autocratic Takeovers & the Quiet Revelations it Makes About Modern Democracy

Drawing on Ram Chandra Guha's comparison of Mussolini's Italy and Modi's India, this long read examines how democracies slide into authoritarianism not through sudden rupture but through incremental normalisation — and what the historical record of regimes that did end tells us about the one we are in.

BY KANIKA SOLANKI

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RAM CHANDRA GUHA, 'READING ABOUT MUSSOLINI'S ITALY IN MODI'S INDIA',
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APLUSTOPPER USER SASTRY (SIC), NARENDRA MODI ESSAY FOR STUDENTS AND
CHILDREN IN ENGLISH, MARCH 2023

Nearly three years ago now, in an article for Scroll^[1], Ram Chandra Guha, in what remains, 3 years hence, an impeccable & scathing critique of the Bhartiya Janata Party's neo fascist politics, managed to identify & illustrate a congruence between Mussolini's Italy & what he called 'Modi's India', that - if you care to take a closer look at - reveals something teeth gnashingly ugly about not just the Indian Democracy or what it has become in the years since it was so founded, but about the very structure of the modern democracy itself.

It is imminent to mention here that the foundation of the following case was, as a matter of fact, not an investigative report at all, but an opinion piece, one that sought to remember & commemorate the most significant dictatorships of postmodern history, not for what they were but for what their legacy signifies: their end. But the only evidence we have to the fact that they *did* end has been provided by those who survived them. And isn't it convenient that through all the years of history that can be found squashed into our school textbooks, the good guys have always won?

It is tempting to celebrate what one is used to as normal. To miss things that would be obvious from far away when they are right under your nose. History is convenient in that sense. It allows the othering of disaster & tragedy the way that only proximity can prevent. People like to perceive themselves as n degrees separated from what is not in their immediate vicinity, & for good reason. Status quo protects you; it makes you invincible to all that is abnormal, extreme, definitively unreasonable. But there is no worth to this comfort unless it is accompanied by the realization that it is only illusory. That 'it won't happen to us because we're not them' is not an argument that will prevent circumstances from turning against you, merely reduce your chances of identifying & therefore surviving them. It is important to isolate incident from assessment, to verify for yourself that your interpretation of the hot pink soda in front of you does not change from strawberry to guava as the label on the machine nozzle does, and to know that the past is only evidentiary in retrospect.

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Born on the 29th of July 1883 in Dovia Di Predappio, a small town in the province of Forli in Romagna, Mussolini's early political views were heavily influenced by his father who idolized 19th century Italian nationalist figures with humanist tendencies such as Carlo Pisacane, Giuseppe Mazzini and Giuseppe Garibaldi. He studied the ideas of the philosopher Friedrich Nietzsche, the sociologist Vilfredo Pareto and the syndicalist Georges Sorel. Mussolini also later credited the Christian socialist Charles Peguy and the syndicalist Hubert Lagardelle as some of his influences.

He became active in the Italian socialist movement in Switzerland, working for the paper L'Avvenire Del Lavoratore, organizing meetings, giving speeches to workers, and serving as secretary of the Italian workers' union in Lausanne. He was briefly imprisoned and upon release, became editor of the organization's newspaper, Avanti (meaning 'forward'), the socialist newspaper, which gave him a larger megaphone and expanded his influence.

In 1915, he joined the Italian army and fought on the front lines, reaching the rank of corporal before being wounded and discharged from the military. The Italian Socialist party decided to oppose the war after anti militarist protestors had been killed, resulting in a general strike called Red Week. On March 23, 1919, Benito Mussolini founded the Fascist Party. The fascist movement proclaimed opposition to social class decimation and supported nationalist sentiments. He hoped to raise Italy to the levels of its great Roman past. He criticized the Italian government for weakness at the Treaty of Versailles. Capitalizing on public discontent following World War I, he organized a paramilitary unit known as the 'Black Shirts', who terrorized political opponents and helped increase Fascist influence. As Italy slipped into political chaos, Mussolini declared that only he could restore order and was given the authority in 1922 as prime minister, & thus Benito was reborn, as 'Il Duce'.¹²

'The Leader'.

Our concern with the evolution of global dictatorship traces back to the 19th century, when the word 'fascism' became a phenomenon of international concern. What a fascist, in Italy then & in India now, believes is essentially that liberal democracy is obsolete and thus regards the complete mobilization of society under a totalitarian one-party state to be necessary to prepare a nation for armed conflict and to respond effectively to economic difficulties.³ Such a state is then to be led by a strong leader such as a dictator and its martial government is to compose of the members of the governing party – to forge national unity and maintain a stable and orderly society.

Sound familiar?

Further down the line, the state rejects assertions that violence is automatically negative in nature and views political violence, war and imperialism as means that can achieve national rejuvenation. Fascists advocate a mixed economy, with the principal goal of achieving autocracy through protectionist and interventionist economic policies.⁴ Fundamentally, definitively, the dictatorial state is identical to the democratic one, the only difference being in perception. Marketing. If one is to swap out the word dictator for Prime Minister, as many in history officially have been, the political structure is indistinguishable from that of, not just an acceptable democracy, but an ideal one. This is where the blunder is, & this is where one must rectify approach.

Structure. That is what one needs to follow. How is Ram Chandra Guha able to draw a one to one parallel between Mussolini's country to ours in the present day, over Patria & Gloria & Media & Law, when in the face of the highly educated, individualist, idealist, power hungry war fought veteran that was Benito Mussolini, Modi looks but like the classroom retard? Because the similarities he found (the similarities that matter) are not personal, but structural. Dictatorships are not, & never have been, about the dictators, but about their polity. The men are decoys, they never mattered, not to their nations, not to their fates, & not to our futures. History's relentless insistence to focus on them, & on the drama of their beings is asinine & shallow, a blind spotted logical fallacy, preoccupied with sensation. This is why history keeps repeating, because history herself refuses to recognize that an empirical observation worth making is not that at the forefront of dictatorships are men who are good at giving speeches, but men who *are* giving speeches.

Incident over assertion.

Born 17 September 1950 in Vadnagar, Gujarat, Narendra Damodardas Modi was the third of six children and helped his father selling tea. At the age of 8, he met Lakshmanrao Inamdar, who inducted him as a junior cadet in the RSS & is known to be Modi's political 'guru'. In 1967, he completed his schooling, & a year later was married to Jashodaben, whom he soon left to pursue his political ambitions. In 1970, he became a full-time campaigner of RSS. In 1983, he completed his master's degree in political science from Gujarat University.

In 1988, Modi was elected as the organizing secretary of BJP's Gujarat unit and in 1995, became its National Secretary. In 2001, Modi was appointed the Chief Minister of Gujarat. In 2002, in the aftermath of the Godhra carnage, he submitted his resignation. However, it was rejected. Under Modi, Gujarat flourished. A number of projects for groundwater conservation were undertaken. As a result of better irrigation measures, Gujarat's yield of cotton became the largest in India. Rural electricity supply was improved. In 2013, Modi was announced as BJP's Prime Ministerial candidate and contested from Varanasi and Vadodara. Modi effectively used social media like Twitter and Facebook for his campaigns, surrounding himself with a mythic & messianic public image. He was sworn in on 26 May 2014, from which point on he has remained in office till date, having recontested for a successive term & won.

Much of Modi's life & personal background remains, while it hasn't yet been quite removed from our memory, & while those of us who do in fact possess said memory directly are still alive, subject to immense controversy. The two paragraphs above have been primarily sourced from a website called aplustopper.com^[2], in a ready to plagiarize essay about the prime minister written for school children of age 6 through 10. An essay that opened with the words, "he waved and a million Indians joined him in the chorus which he led. He, Narendra Modi, sang the song of India's development and the road ahead."

"India has been longing for a change since a long (sic). Freedom from corruption and communalism, education and jobs for all are some of India's top concerns. India has reposed a lot of faith in this 'son of the soil'. Let us hope Modi to be India's next 'Miracle Man'."

APLUSTOPPER USER SASTRY (SIC), NARENDRA MODI ESSAY FOR STUDENTS AND CHILDREN IN ENGLISH, MARCH 2023

Much of the disingenuity in the 2 paragraphs above, despite the more obvious & exaggerated instances like the aforequoted excerpt having been intentionally removed, will nevertheless translate to readers of the present day. But subtract our proximity & the firsthand knowledge that we have to discrepancies & debates surrounding seemingly insignificant details like Modi's wife (whom he didn't so much leave to pursue politics as abandoned & buried trace of doing so to protect his affiliations with religious extremist groups), his master's degree (remotely acquired, potentially doctored & with a controversial first class) & the irony of the 1 sentence mention of Godhra all become lost.

This retrospective continuity, ultimately, is what makes up for Modi's lack of impressiveness as a person & as a leader of State. These portrayals & their being found increasingly in children's media & educational material may appear harmless & at most, hilarious, due to its contrast with the buffoonish & mockable image of Modi that older audiences default to, but is as sinister if not more than any other structural parallel observed here.

It is here that the construction of the 'myth' (The Leader, The Führer, The Son of the Soil) begins. His lack of military ability & experience, his frivolous & demagogueruatic policies (yesterday, a crowd wearing garlands & carrying megaphones & a sound system carried a pot through the streets asking people to donate handfuls of earth for the graves of soldiers paraded through the capital's streets, another of Modi's self-proclaimed ingenious schemes for public welfare), his involvements in corruption & criminal conspiracy, his cartoonish ignorance on political or economic matters - the ill-founded joke of his international persona, all cease to matter. It is Modi's India, that begins to replicate Mussolini's Italy, even if Modi himself cannot. And one can argue that this can never be the case. That Modi's regime will always differ from that of Mussolini's fundamentally because he was democratically elected: chosen. But so was Assad. So was Machado. So was Batista.

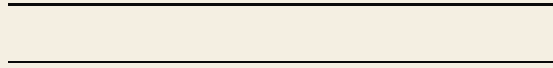
Mussolini, Hitler, & Musharraf were all leaders that were chosen *by* their countries, one way or another, regardless of what name you give to the process & regardless of how stupid it makes them feel to hear it. In fact, most dictators have democratic origins, that is why they are called dictators, & not monarchs or compatriots or some other sugar-coated variation of the name, despite playing the same role.

The problem is not that the state of Indian politics bears a closer resemblance to the autocratic state than it does to democracy, but that the structure of the modern democracy itself works parallel to its sister States: the oligarchy & the dictatorship. Business conglomerates form the oligarchal tier, the self-serving multi-party system forms the democratic one, & the majoritarian central politics & glorified Leader of state form the dictatorial one. It is not the erasure of democracy that we need to fear, but the corruption of it. Because the differences between Modi's India & Mussolini's Italy, those assertive differences that we've been putting aside till now, are not what protect our states from turning into theirs, but what prevented theirs from lasting. It *is* the radicalism & fast-moving catalysts absent from our broken democracy that lead to the rise of the fascist state, but they are also what lead to its demise. And it is this very absence that ensures the indefinite sustenance of our country as it stands, stagnated, while rotting it from the inside out.

In Italy, Mussolini founded the Fascist party which organized several right-wing groups into a single force. The National Democratic Alliance, a right wing conservative Indian political alliance today controls the government of India as well as the government of 15 Indian states and one Union territory. The outbreak of World War I had resulted in a surge of Italian nationalism and the war was supported by a variety of political fractions. Hindu nationalist sentiment now forms the forerunning point of the BJP's & it's sister organizations' political agenda. 'He carried out the extensive public works and reduced unemployment. The country was thriving and was convinced that he made a place in history and would take the nation to new heights, with the vision to the empire's ancient glory (sic).' Who are these sentences about?

In 1923, the Italian government passed the Acerbo law, which transformed Italy into a single constituency. A hundred years later, the Indian government has proposed & is in the process of implementing a constitution amending act^[3] that will unify the country's composite& near continuous election cycle into a single one, cutting off chances of regional parties & recreating a system which when active, had as many as 4 states under presidential rule at a time.

We are frogs in gradually heating water, & we will boil to death before we leave.



Kanika Solanki is currently a student at the University of Delhi, pursuing her bachelor's in journalism. She has a keen interest in photography and graphic designing & has previously interned as a content writer. The quest for gaining new information and experiences keeps her going. Kanika has co-authored this piece with her senior & editor, Mouli Sharma.

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SOURCES & REFERENCES

^[1] article for Scroll

^[2] [aplustopper.com](#)

^[3] constitution amending act